

looked into several options available in the market, but settled for XEN virtualisation, which is under GPL and is an open source platform.

“Over the next few months, the environment not only proved to be absolutely stable but also offered the flexibility required for rapid cloning, backup, server to server migration. The fact that the servers were virtual made no difference to the Oracle EBS application and database admins. We deployed our entire data centre on open source by using XEN virtualisation, iptables as firewall, Snort as the Intrusion Detection System, Squid as the Internet filter/proxy, Nagios as the network and device monitoring system, and Zci and OCS for asset management.

“SEW’s construction sites are spread across the length and breadth of the nation, with some of them located in hard to reach places such as Arunachal Pradesh and North Sikkim. Our employees had to trek several kilometres to make a phone call and get in touch with the head office. We set up a nationwide VoIP infrastructure on Asterisk running in the XEN environment that handles more than half a million minutes of voice calls per year.”

The challenges were many

Shivaram’s belief in open source technology drove him to convince more and more colleagues in the industry about its benefits.

He reminisces, “While we were discussing our ERP deployment on open source, the management was concerned about the post ‘go-live’ support. The ERP implementation partner recommended against virtualisation since it was not supported by Oracle at that point of time. Since we were still in the ‘development’ mode, we went ahead and took that risk. We were cautioned that it was not a standard procedure or a good practice. Our CIO, Sidhartha Meka, supported us by trusting our technical expertise.”

At the end of the day, it appears that what is required is conviction and the technical knowhow. Things fall in place if these two are perfectly aligned. Eventually, when the application was finally ready for production level deployment, Oracle EBS was certified on Oracle’s VM.

Today, when he looks back, Shivaram feels good about the fact that he could continue with his passion for open source technology, while benefiting the company.

He says, “Being a non-IT company, we always have budget limitations for IT infrastructure – which was yet another reason to implement open source apps, apart from my passion for open source technology. When we went on to search for the appropriate open source software for our company, we found quite a few alternatives. The beauty of open source is that it allows complete flexibility and one can do modifications as



Shivaram Yeruva, IT infra lead,
SEW Infrastructure Ltd

per the requirements. We found it easier to manage after deployment, as we could get immense support from the forums.”

However, Shivaram’s quest did not end here. He wanted to leverage open source tools to enable the end users as well. He says, “We have deployed many open source software at the user level, which has

helped in reducing our costs to a large extent. Earlier, we used to purchase office tools and PDF tools to convert the documents. But now, we are using OpenOffice and LibreOffice; we have many templates available for the same. We use DIA for flow charts or organisation charts. Gradually, we trained our employees to use Linux as their desktop OS. Initially, it was an uphill task, because they were used to Windows and breaking that mindset does take time. With some investment in training, and identifying and supporting the key change catalysts in the organisation, we are getting good results in the transition from Windows to Linux. After some initial hiccups, things have been smooth.”

Shivaram explains that his job as an IT manager is to ensure the organisation’s growth, both technically and financially. Adoption of open source technology definitely required that extra bit of effort, but his conviction to make it was much bigger than the hurdles he faced.

He summarizes his experience saying, “Go for open source and try it; later, you’ll love the flexibility it offers. Modify it as per your needs and cut your capital expenditure. You will find new information on the forums every now and then that will help you enable innovative solutions. You will not be stuck with a vendor’s development and release cycles, and the frustration of dealing with its support processes for every issue.”

Flexibility, and freedom that is free of cost!

SEW has saved at least Rs 100 million by believing in open source solutions. Typically, provisioning of extra capacity and users requires lengthy budgetary approval processes that hamper business expansion. With open source this is hardly a challenge. Also, the use of open source architectures plants the organisation in an open standards oriented environment. This contrasts with the platform-specific dependencies on the vendors’ proprietary technologies that are hard to migrate away from, and also require specialised skills to manage. **END** 

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